



Sorted Once, Seated All Term

A Comparison of Week-One Diagnostic Table-Colour Groups Against Week-Nine Tutorial Performance

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The problem

First-year tutorial rooms sort students into colour-coded table groups from a single week-one diagnostic quiz. Despite growing interest in responsive small-group teaching, little is known about whether that first placement still describes anyone by the time assessment begins.

Research questions

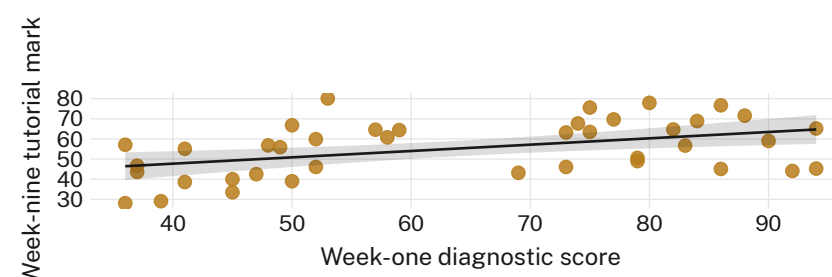
- Does week-one table colour predict week-nine tutorial performance?
- How often does a student's marked ability diverge from their assigned colour?
- Do tutors reassign colours as divergence accumulates?

Study design

- 214 first-year students · 3 table colours (gold, ink, grey-tint) · 9 weekly tutorial marks · one teaching period
- Week-one diagnostic score fixed table placement; week-nine mark set from a blinded tutor rubric
- Reassignment tracked as a binary flag per student per week; no manual override recorded outside the flag

What we found

Week-one colour explains a shrinking share of week-nine performance (partial R^2 falling from 0.41 to 0.09 across the term); most students who crossed a full grade band were never reassigned.



Week-nine marks correlate only weakly with the week-one score that fixed each student's colour ($r = 0.24$, $n = 214$).

Implications

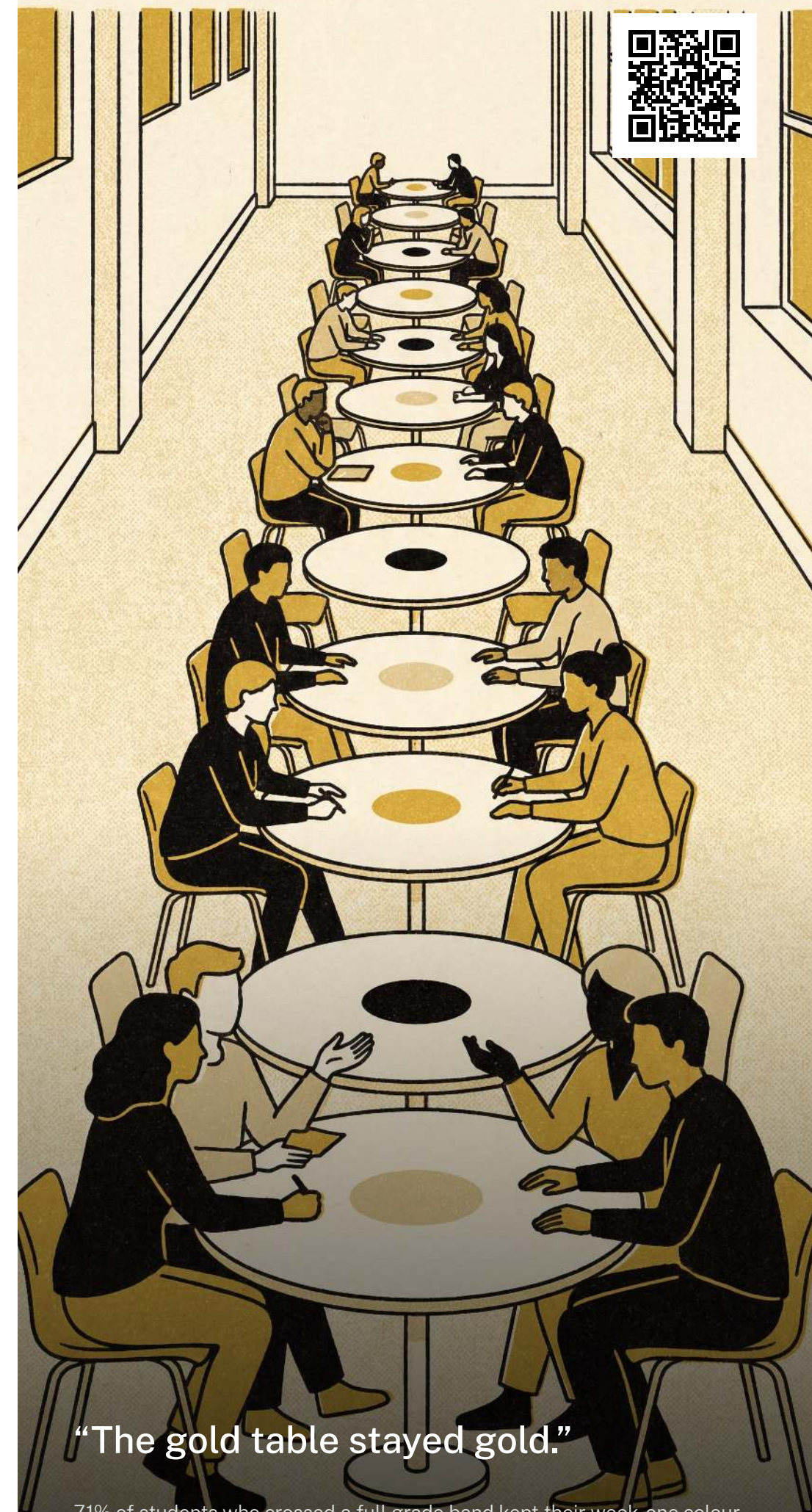
Table colour persists as shorthand long after it stops describing performance; reassignment is procedurally possible but practically rare. Next: trial a mid-term recolour keyed to the same rubric.

Selected references

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“The gold table stayed gold.”

71% of students who crossed a full grade band kept their week-one colour through week nine.